

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Global data · 2023 · DALYs per 100,000

Source: Our World in Data / IHME Global Burden of Disease (2025)

Hundreds of Millions Affected: 1 in 3 Women and 1 in 5 Men Face Major Depression

1 in 3

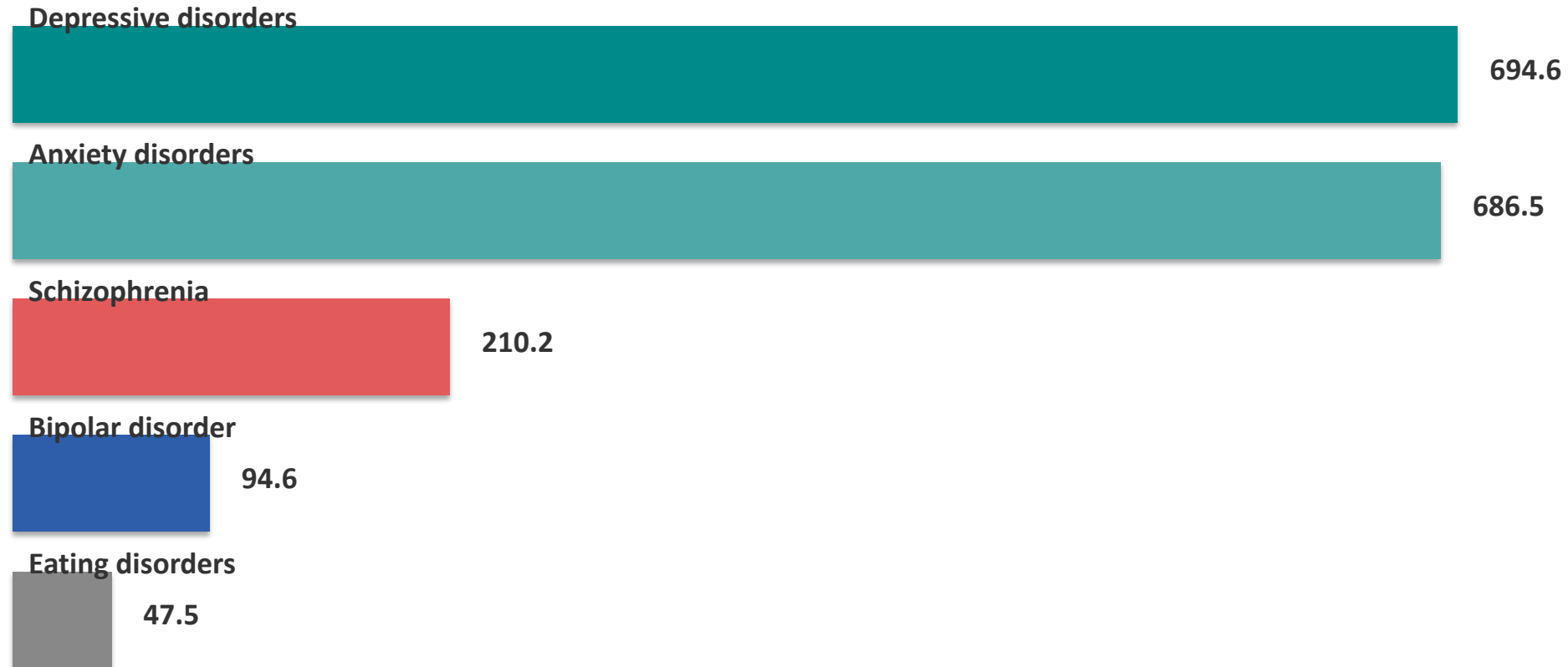
women will experience
major depression in their lifetime

1 in 5

men will experience
major depression in their lifetime

Mental health conditions span from common disorders (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe conditions (schizophrenia, bipolar disorder). Hundreds of millions of people suffer from mental health conditions each year, and many more experience them over their lifetimes. Poor mental health affects well-being, the ability to work, and relationships with friends, family, and community.

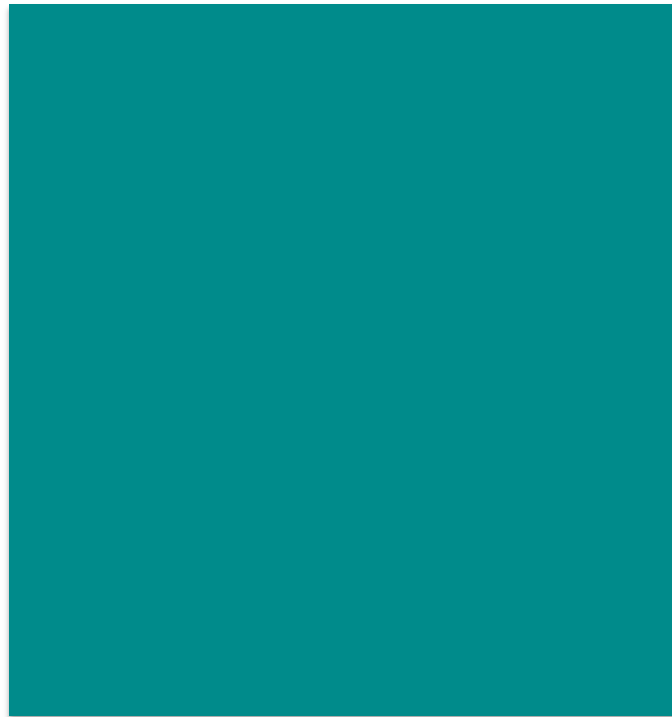
Depression and Anxiety Dominate: ~695 and ~687 DALYs per 100K Respectively



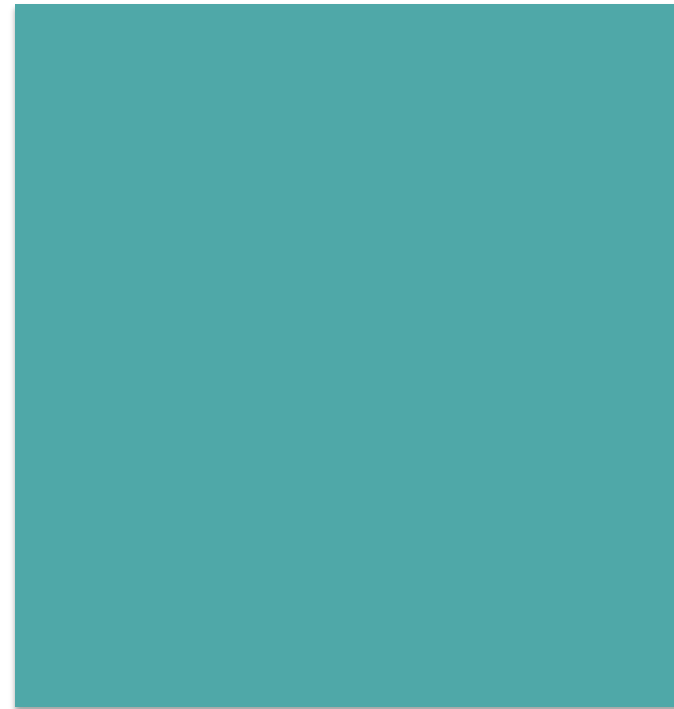
Source: IHME Global Burden of Disease (2023) · DALYs per 100,000 people

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden Worldwide

Together they account for roughly 80% of the total mental health disease burden across these five categories



Depressive disorders

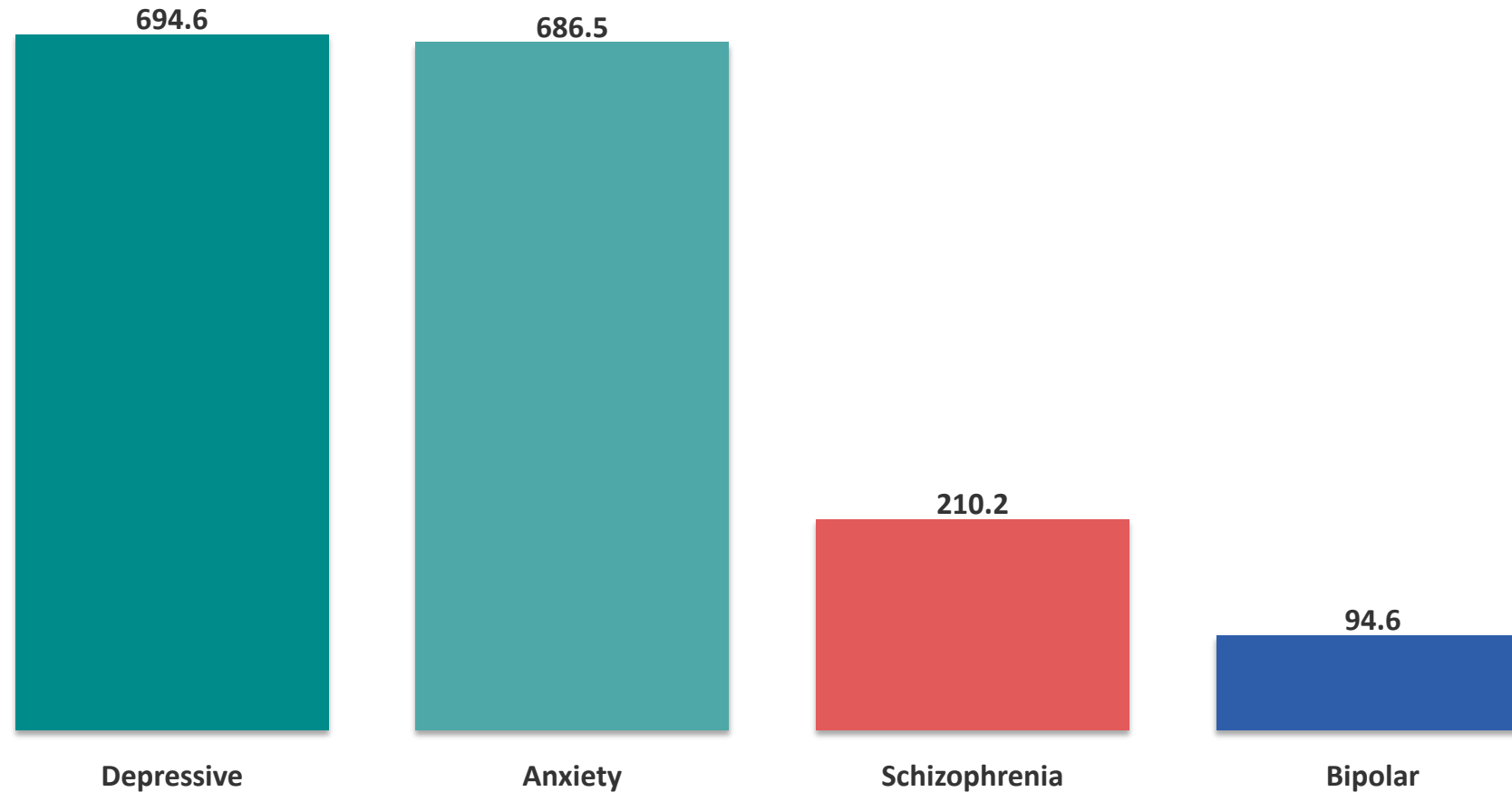


Anxiety disorders

Source: IHME Global Burden of Disease (2023) 694.6 DALYs / 100K

686.5 DALYs / 100K

Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder: Lower Prevalence but Severe Individual Impact



While population-level burden is lower for schizophrenia and bipolar disorder, individual severity and disability are high. Schizophrenia contributes 210.2 DALYs per 100,000 — reflecting the severe disability associated with the condition.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

Stigma

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or even to people they know.

Access

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries.

Quality

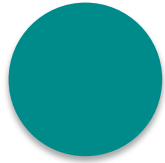
Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality.

Underreporting

Discomfort with disclosure makes it difficult to estimate true prevalence — the actual burden may be higher.

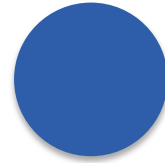
Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced. Despite this, treatment is often lacking or of poor quality. Good data is essential to understand these conditions — how, when, and why they occur, how many people are affected, and how they can be treated effectively and safely.

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations



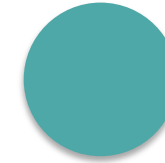
Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings as a primary treatment approach for anxiety and depression.



Religious or Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide as a culturally embedded coping mechanism.



Talking to Friends or Family

A widely reported coping mechanism across diverse populations and income levels.

The diversity of coping strategies underscores that mental health responses are shaped by cultural, economic, and healthcare system factors. Policy interventions must account for these differences rather than applying a one-size-fits-all approach.

Key Takeaways: Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Treatment Gap

- Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs (~695 and ~687 per 100K respectively).
- Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder carry disproportionate individual burden relative to their prevalence (210.2 and 94.6 DALYs per 100K).
- Effective treatment exists, but access and quality remain inadequate — especially in low- and middle-income countries.
- Stigma suppresses both help-seeking behavior and accurate prevalence data, meaning the true burden is likely underestimated.
- Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.